

In a Drunken STATE

Kerala breaks its own record in liquor consumption to the delight of a bankrupt Government but at a heavy social cost

By M.G. Radhakrishnan

It is called God's own country. But apparently the god ruling Kerala seems to be Bacchus. Known as a model state for its excellent human development record, Kerala tops the country in alcohol consumption as well. The state's bacchanalia breaks all records when it celebrates its traditional festivals—religious or otherwise. As usual, the recent Onam festival, Kerala's biggest harvest festival that culminated on September 2, was no exception as it notched up a new record in alcohol consumption. The seven-day Onam week, excluding one dry day, saw Kerala gulping down Indian Made Foreign Liquor (IMFL) worth Rs 154.44 crore as against Rs 126.07 crore last year, registering an increase of 41.53 per cent. The sales peaked on two days before the climactic Thiruvonam when Malayalees guzzled IMFL worth Rs 34 crore as against last year's highest daily figure of Rs 23 crore.

No wonder one of the state's most revered deities is Parassinikadavu Muthappan in Kannur district whose favourite offering is liquor. These days, thanks to the large number of devotees working in the Gulf, Muthappan's favourite offering (as reported by the priests) is Scotch whisky rather than the traditional arrack or toddy.

Kerala's binge drinking during festivals is just the icing on the cake, for the state's alcohol consumption has been rising alarmingly for many years. Annual IMFL sales have risen by about Rs 1,000 crore in the past decade. Notwithstanding the global recession, sales crossed an all-time high of Rs 4,600 crore in 2008-09, up from Rs 3,670 crore in the previous

year. Ten years back, it was barely Rs 1,000 crore. The state-owned Kerala State Beverages Corporation (KSBC), which is the IMFL's monopoly distributor in the state, is the only public sector undertaking that has consistently made profits, from Rs 17.52 crore in 1997-98 to over Rs 100 crore in 2008-09. According to a study by IIM-Kozhikode, the figures have even crossed KSBC's own expectations and projections.

This is not barely an inflationary rise for sales volumes too have touched 175 lakh cases of IMFL last year from about 88 lakh cases 10 years back. The mind-boggling figures pertain only to KSBC's official sales made through its 330 outlets. Add to it the liquor sold through 56 bars and the outlets of the co-operative Consumerfed and the average daily sales during the Onam week alone would easily cross Rs 30 crore as against the average daily sales of about Rs 10 crore. If one considers the amount of toddy, a popular liquor sold through the 5,000-odd registered outlets, the total consumption would be staggering. Not just toddy, but the highly popular arrack, another country liquor banned since 1995, flows freely across the state. In fact, its value was put at Rs 13,000 crore a year by the state Police Director-General Jacob Punnuse. According to the industry sources, alcohol sales in the state are actually worth Rs 20,000 crore. Rum sells the most, followed by brandy and whisky.

Ironically, the KSBC has now decided to set up a modern Rs 100-crore multi-specialty de-addiction centre and hospital in Thiruvananthapuram. According to the Alcohol and Drug Information Centre (ADIC), an NGO, Kerala tops the country in alcohol

